

Web Scraping: A Key Tool in Data Science

Estimated Effort: 5 mins

Introduction

Web scraping, also known as web harvesting or web data extraction, is a technique used to extract large amounts of data from websites. The data on websites is unstructured, and web scraping enables us to convert it into a structured form.

Importance of Web Scraping in Data Science

In the field of data science, web scraping plays an integral role. It is used for various purposes such as:

- 1. **Data Collection:** Web scraping is a primary method of collecting data from the internet. This data can be used for analysis, research, etc.
- 2. **Real-time Application:** Web scraping is used for real-time applications like weather updates, price comparison, etc.
- 3. **Machine Learning:** Web scraping provides the data needed to train machine learning models.

Web Scraping with Python

Python provides several libraries for web scraping. Here are some of them:

- 1. **BeautifulSoup:** BeautifulSoup is a Python library used for web scraping purposes to pull the data out of HTML and XML files. It creates a parse tree from page source code that can be used to extract data in a hierarchical and more readable manner.

```
from bs4 import BeautifulSoup
import requests
URL = "http://www.example.com"
page = requests.get(URL)
soup = BeautifulSoup(page.content, "html.parser")
```

- 2. **Scrapy:** Scrapy is an open-source and collaborative web crawling framework for Python. It is used to extract the data from the website.

```
import scrapy
class QuotesSpider(scrapy.Spider):
    name = "quotes"
    start_urls = ['http://quotes.toscrape.com/tag/humor/']
    def parse(self, response):
        for quote in response.css('div.quote'):
            yield {'quote': quote.css('span.text::text').get()}}
```

- 3. **Selenium:** Selenium is a tool used for controlling web browsers through programs and automating browser tasks.

```
from selenium import webdriver
driver = webdriver.Firefox()
driver.get("http://www.example.com")
```

Applications of Web Scraping

Web scraping is used in various fields and has many applications:

- 1. **Price Comparison:** Services such as Price24 use web scraping to collect data from online shopping websites and use it to compare the prices of products.
- 2. **Email address gathering:** Many companies that use email as a medium for marketing, use web scraping to collect email ID and then send bulk emails.
- 3. **Social Media Scraping:** Web scraping is used to collect data from Social Media websites such as Twitter to find out what's trending.

Conclusion

Web scraping is an essential skill in the fast-growing world of data science. It provides the ability to turn the web into a source of data that can be analyzed, processed, and used for a variety of applications. However, it's important to remember that one should use web scraping responsibly and ethically, respecting the terms of use or robots.txt files of the websites being scraped.

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